Medical ethics

Ethics: The science of morals. A society's obligations and responsibilities.

Whether discussing child raising, politics, farming or rules and regulations, we all have opinions about what is 'right' and what is 'wrong', what is 'good' and what is 'bad'. The medical community is not excused from being expected to follow acceptable procedures with regard to their practices.

There is no single set of international rules because what is considered acceptable in one country can be considered unacceptable in another. For example, in Western countries, like Australia, an adult will discuss their ailment and possible treatment with their doctor. The doctor will only invite family members into the discussion with the patient's consent. In many Eastern countries, such as China, the patient's condition is discussed with the whole family – in particular the elder relatives – and decisions are made as a group. The patient is not necessarily given a choice about this.

1 State two advantages and two disadvantages for the 'Western' and 'Eastern' ethics when it comes to discussing a patient's condition.

Many people have argued that teaching ethics to members of the scientific community is a waste of time. They believe technology is moving at such an alarming rate that the ethical issues can't possibly be imagined and often, once they are realised, it is too late to act. However, most will agree that it is important to have a standard of practice that should always be considered and that using these guidelines, individual cases can be measured against them.

Doctors are now being placed in difficult positions. Many years ago euthanasia, genetic engineering, IVF and stem cell research were unknown. Today, these present complex ethical issues. For some people, any kind of modification to the human body is unacceptable – *'we shouldn't play God'*. Culture and religion play important roles in ethical considerations. For some religions, blood transfusions are never permitted (even if a life would be saved) whereas others believe that if humans were given the gift of learning how to do these things, they should be done provided they would improve the quality of life of the patient.

Examples of contemporary ethical issues include:

- *'designer babies'*: selecting embryos with characteristics the parents want
- the rights of the unborn
- gene technology: genetic modification, genetic screening, cloning etc
- organ transplants
- the treatment of living subjects for experiment trials (humans and other animals)
- euthanasia: 'humanely' killing a person 'before their time' (*eu* well, *thanatos* death)
- involuntary sterilisation, eg to prevent a mentally impaired individual from becoming a parent
- surrogate mothers: 'substitutes' who carry a developing baby
- sperm and egg donation and IVF techniques

Genetic screening

In Australia today, most pregnant women are given the opportunity to choose whether they want to screen for the presence of a genetic disorder in their developing child. If the genetic screening does identify a disorder, several things must be considered. These include: how badly affected will the child be? If it is mild disorder, will the child be able to live a normal or near-normal life? What are the costs involved? Will expensive treatments and/or equipment be required? How will the rest of the family be affected?

Once a disorder is identified, parents must consider its severity. A mild disorder will present a different set of circumstances than a severe one. The long-term and short-term considerations must also be noted. If a baby will be born with a severe condition it may die young. This means the parents will be faced with the additional trauma of the death of a child. Alternatively, if the child can live to a fairly old age but will be severely impaired, is it fair to let them (and the rest of the family) suffer?

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2 Many people disagree with testing a developing embryo to determine if it is carrying a potentially disabling condition. Do you agree or disagree with this? Why?

3 When tests mentioned in question 2 show the presence of a genetic disorder, the parents could be faced with other ethical issues. State one other possible ethical issue that could arise.

A developing embryo tests positive for a genetic disorder such as Cystic Fibrosis. The father's side of the family says the child has the right to live. The mother's side disagrees saying it is unfair to put the family through the heartache of watching their child suffer. They also argue that the child doesn't deserve to 'exist' in such a condition, knowing that its siblings are all healthy and 'normal'.

4 What other issues must the family described above have to consider?

5 In the example above which side would you support, the mother's family or the father's? Why?

'The welfare of the patient is the doctor's first and only concern. In the case of a pregnant woman, the doctor cannot possibly be expected to put the welfare of the developing baby before his patient.'

6 Discuss this statement. Do you agree or disagree? Give your reasons.

7 With reference to question 6, when might the welfare of a developing baby become a priority?

Scientific research

Whenever new scientific research is undertaken many things must be considered before the project can proceed. Ethics committees, made up of a broad range of the community (scientists, religious etc) are involved in the decision making once the 'science' has been mapped out in theory. Considerations include:

- What is the purpose of the procedure?
- If live experimental subjects are required (of any species, including human) will any suffering be involved? If so, can the researchers prove that the experiments cannot possibly be done any other way and that they will use the minimum number of subjects to obtain valid results, eg will not cause suffering to more subjects than is necessary?
- Will the procedure/experiment work in practice as well as in theory?
- How will it be done? Full details to be given: costs, methods, length of time etc.
- It is ethically acceptable? (A particularly hot issue when suffering will be involved.)
- Who will pay for it? (taxpayer, business community, government etc)

8 Do you consider it ethical for the taxpayer to fully or partially fund expensive treatments and/or equipment (such as specialists, wheelchairs etc)? Explain your choice.

Jenner and vaccination

Edward Jenner (1749–1823) was a country doctor in the west of England. He is famous for his work on smallpox. This disease was a major killer of infants and young children in the eighteenth century. He noticed that people who had suffered the (relatively) mild disease cowpox did not catch smallpox. He experimented, putting some pus from cowpox blisters from a milkmaid into a young boy and later injecting the boy with smallpox. The boy was ill for a few days but fully recovered. This process of *vaccination* (Latin *vacca*, a cow) immunised against smallpox.

9 Discuss the 'rights' and 'wrongs' of Jenner experimenting with a live subject.

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